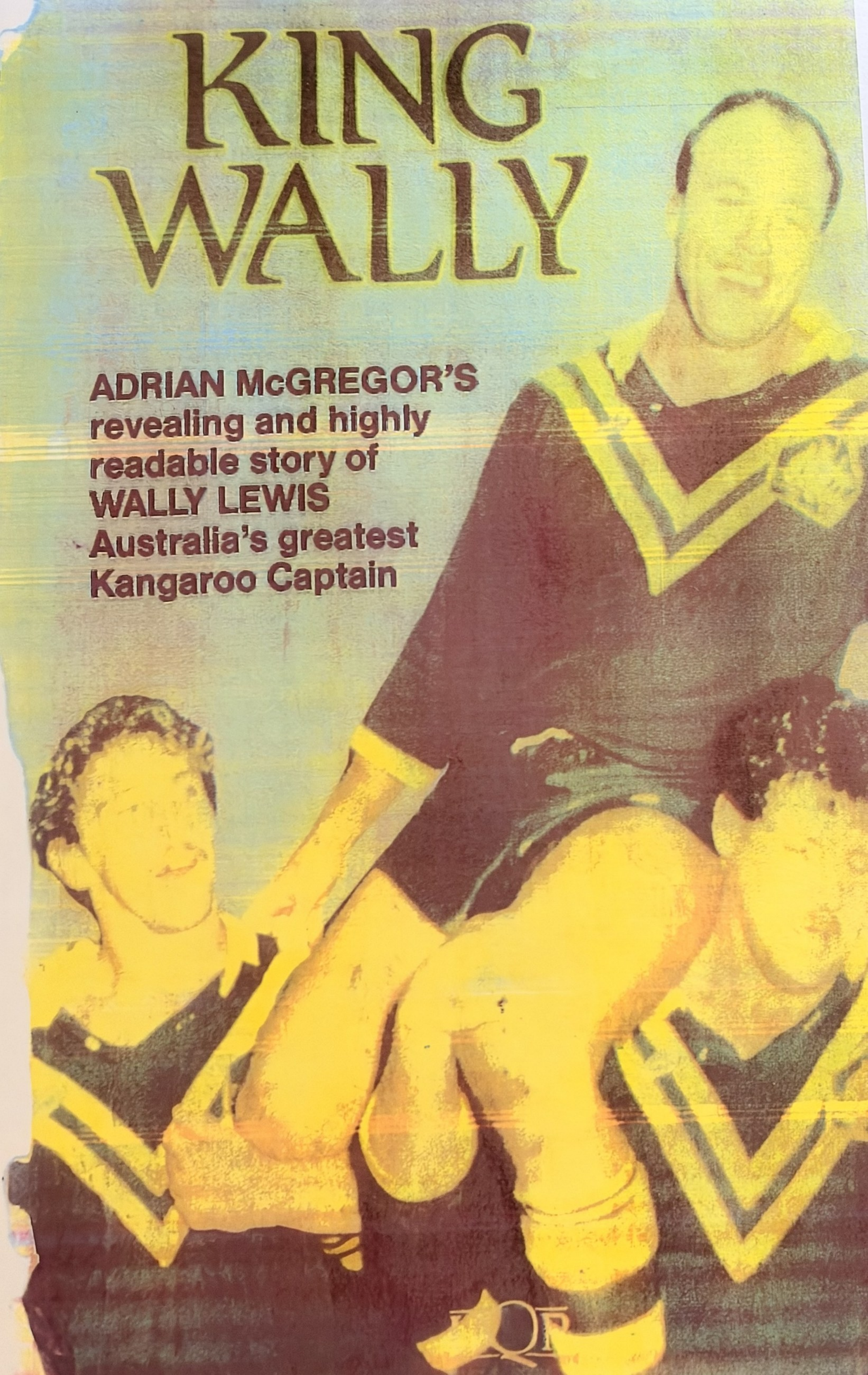


KING WALLY

ADRIAN MCGREGOR'S
revealing and highly
readable story of
WALLY LEWIS
Australia's greatest
Kangaroo Captain



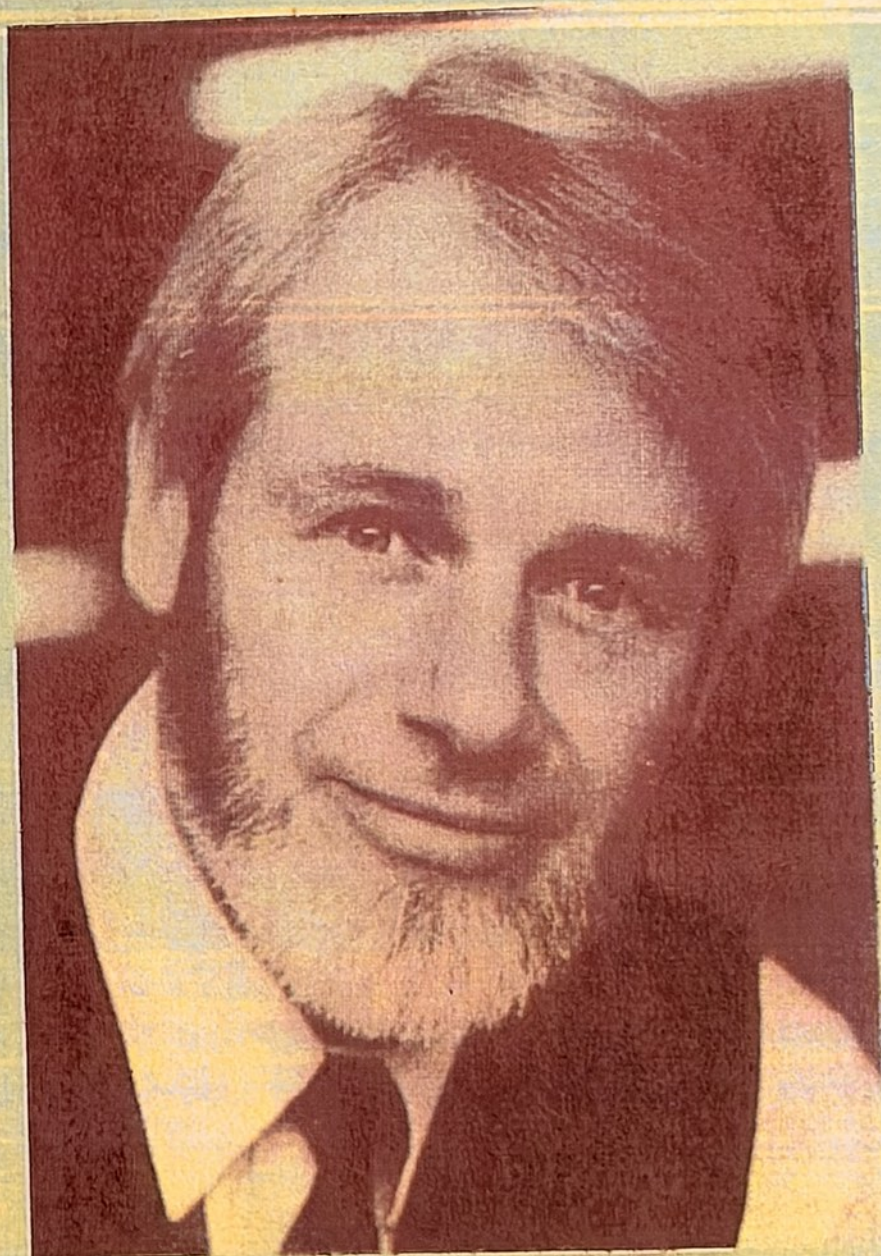
UQP NONFICTION

Wally Lewis is the undisputed King of Australian Rugby League, a player of awesome skill and power. He is also League's most gifted captain, who led the victorious 1986 Kangaroo tour of Great Britain.

Prize-winning feature writer Adrian McGregor has put together all the inside stories, the drama, disasters and triumphs of Wally Lewis's eventful life, from working class son to the country's highest paid footballer. For sports fans, this compelling story will be the most talked about book of the year.

"After Australia narrowly held off New Zealand in a violent Test clash, I watched a compassionate Wally Lewis move slowly around the dressingroom, quietly talking to each of his bruised and bleeding players. They'd been through hell for him. I decided to find out more about the special qualities of such a champion."

Adrian McGregor



Cover design by Christopher McVinish using photograph courtesy of Oz Sport Photography

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Richard Leslie, whose girlfriend was overseas. "Let's go," said Wally. Money would be no object, he assured Richard generously, for either of them. Both were keen to see more of England than they had from their coach windows on the schoolboys rugby union tour. They stayed near Sloane Square, visited the family in Llandudno, North Wales, who had billeted them as schoolboys and, back in London, booked a two-week skiing holiday in Achen-Kirch, a small tourist village in Austria.

Neither could ski, but after some instruction the boys struck out for the slopes. Richard cautiously wound his way down but Wally hopped off the T-bar at the top and with a scream took off. Hurt himself? "That's not in Wally's mind when he's enjoying himself," said Richard. "I saw him fall once and slide into a big pile of snow which stopped him hitting a forest." Richard had been water-skiing with Wally so he knew Wally's style. "It was always open the throttle and flat chat."

Wally also showed a different prowess in the après-ski scene. The equivalent of the Australian arm wrestle as a test of strength at this lodge was a leg wrestle. Contestants lay on their backs, head to head, hooked arms and swung their right leg over their head to lock them behind the knee. The stronger person would flip his opponent over in a backwards roll. The licensee of the lodge was a powerful, blocky, forty-year-old Austrian reputed to be undefeated in fifteen years. He happily flipped guests over, laughing and joking the whole time. Richard, who was bigger than Wally, had a go but was defeated. Then it was Wally's turn to be victim, to give everyone gathered around the huge log fire a laugh. Richard saw Wally's expression alter and suddenly knew the Lewis family strength, an incredible determination, had been invoked.

Wally flipped the Austrian. The locals cheered and clapped, the licensee looked surprised and explained to Wally that he had not been ready. "Oh well, let's go again," offered Wally. Over went the licensee again. He could not believe it. The locals crowded around the new champion and patted his back. "Very strong man, very strong," they praised. "You have free schnapps all night." Eins, zwei, drei, vier and down they went. Wally's victory seemed uncanny to Richard. "It came back to his will,"

he said. "When he needs it he's got the strength of a bull. The strength of a bull."

They returned to London and about three days before Christmas, early in the morning, the phone rang in the flat where they were bunking. It was from Wales for Wally, the Llandudno family, telling him to ring home urgently. Wally called, and the phone rang and rang until a neighbour of the Lewises answered. Brother Edwin had been in a car crash and was not expected to live. The whole family was at the hospital. Wally went to pieces. Richard helped him pack. All air flights to Australia were full over Christmas. "But Wally had to get home," said Richard, "so we went out to Heathrow." He had seen Wally and his brothers, tough kids crash tackling each other on the beach, but he could not have suspected the underlying love that bound them, or the emotional impact Edwin's accident would have. "Wally was totally destroyed," said Richard. "I had him by the arm walking through London because he wasn't watching where he was going. He had tears rolling down his face, his mind was far away at home with his brother. You couldn't talk to him, couldn't communicate at all."

Nor was Wally able to negotiate at the airport. Richard took over. There were no seats available for a fortnight. This was an emergency, look at him, said Richard. Still no way. Wally began to walk from the terminal, weeping, shattered. A British Airways official took sympathy. Wally's plight went to a top executive. A cancellation on Qantas, given to another passenger, was revoked and re-issued to Wally on compassionate grounds. He travelled in the first class, upstairs lounge and at Singapore rang home for the full story. Edwin had been returning from the coast and had turned off at Beenleigh, following a friend whose car had been playing up, to ensure he got home safely. Edwin, seventeen, had spent the weekend at Nobby's surf club and had with him a friend and two fifteen-year-old boys who had spent their first weekend away at the club.

When Edwin had not returned home by 11 p.m. the family grew quiet. June had always impressed upon the boys that if they were delayed they must phone. Fifteen minutes later their phone rang. The police. Edwin's car had been crushed by an oncoming car which failed to take a corner out of Beenleigh and fishtailed into

Edwin. Two boys in the car died outright, one boy was given twenty-four hours to live and one was unscathed. Police were not sure which was Edwin, though they suspected him to be the boy severely injured. Would the parents come to Princess Alexandra Hospital? They learned that Edwin had broken every bone in his body except his nose and one arm. After each twenty-four hours he was given another twenty-four to live and when Wally flew in it continued like that for nearly two weeks. Doctors said that only Edwin's constitution, tough as a mallee maverick, pulled him through. It was nine months before he could leave hospital.

Soon after Christmas Wally, down the coast with Mark Zillman, announced he was going to visit Ed in hospital. Did Mark want to come? "Yeah, but I'll drive," said Mark. If Wally and Chris Roche's hair-raising races around the streets of South Brisbane became the first piece of evidence to support Wally's notorious driving reputation, then this was the second. "No, I'll drive," said Wally. The only reason Mark got in the car was because he presumed Ed's accident would have dampened Wally's usual enthusiasm. Not so. "We sat between 140 and 160 kph the whole way," said Mark. "I was really scared. We visited Ed and coming back Wally said, 'I'll show you Ed's car at Beenleigh.' So we zipped off and saw this car which was an absolute mess. I thought, 'After he's seen that he's got to slow down a bit.' But I reckon he went faster then."

Wally, stricken by his brother's misfortune, still could not imagine that, in any sphere in which his own physical skills had any bearing on his fate, anything could go awry. It was a false judgment, as Wally was soon to discover, but not yet. Not when he was on the brink of participating in one of the most exciting developments in rugby league history.

4 THE YOUNG MAN

1980: Back to Origins

In 1971, on the day that Wally's Queensland primary school team lost their Test against NSW at the SCG by a penalty after the bell, Queensland's new president, Senator Ron McAuliffe, caused a stir at the ground. He requested that for the main match special door attendants be placed on the Queensland dressingroom to keep out poaching Sydney club officials. That was the opening fusillade in McAuliffe's ten-year war to lift Queensland to rugby league supremacy. McAuliffe, after becoming president in 1970, wished he had not accepted it when he examined the low ebb of the code. But he was a fighter. His straight back and squared shoulders are testimony to his days as a professional sprinter when, trained by the great Arthur Postle, he competed in the Stawell Gift in Victoria.

Pressed for a policy upon assuming the presidency, he declared, not wishing to be dull and negative, a three-year plan to defeat NSW. As soon as he put the microscope to the code he saw that was impossible and set about distracting the media's attention by showing there were revolutionary moves afoot. As a joint secretary to the QRL he had been privy to Duncan Thompson's coaching of Queensland in the late 1950s. Thompson traced Queensland's problems to a lack of fitness and worked the state squad so hard that Australian winger, Dennis Flannery, speaking for the team, cautioned they might be leaving their best form on the training track. Thompson asked Flannery, "How many miles do you think you've run today, Dennis?" Flannery guessed about five. "Then relax," said Thompson. "Have you ever heard of Emil